

To see what Aristotle is thinking, let's look at two propositions about a possible future free action of yours.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or Not- P is true.

So it must be that, if the law of the excluded middle is true, then one of these claims is true, and one of them is false.

But to endorse this is just to believe in fate, since it is to say that there is now a truth about whether you will get married on that day.

A second argument for the reality of fate is based, not on logic alone, but on certain widely held views about God.

You will not get married
on June 1, 2027.

You will get married on
June 1, 2027.

It is widely held that God is omniscient, and also widely held that
(for this reason) God knows what actions you will perform in the
future.

But if God knows what actions you will perform in the future, there must be truths about what actions you will perform in the future (otherwise there would be nothing for God to know).

We can put this together into the theological argument for fate.

1. God knows what actions you will perform in the future.
2. If God knows what actions you will perform in the future, there are truths about what actions you will perform in the future.

C. There are truths about what actions you will perform in the future. (1,2)

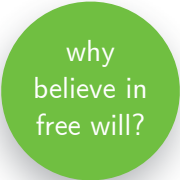
THE THEOLOGICAL ARGUMENT FOR FATE



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

propositions about possible future free action of yours.

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1. God knows what actions you will perform in the future.



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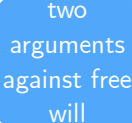
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Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.



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that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

We'll shortly consider some ways of

first let's think about how Edwards'

argument might be related to an argument

responding to Edwards' argument. But

for fatalsn.

there were truths about all our future

Suppose that someone did not believe in

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

actions. Could they give an argument

similar to Edwards' argument?

our future actions.

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

with reference to the being of truth about

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and



2*In the past, there were truths about

5* We have noticed that the fact

God knows that in the future I will

acaioid.

all of our activities.

1. We have no direct facts.

3 We have not at the fact that

(3, 4, 5)

that if it is true that I will perform

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

some action, then I will prefer that

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

then we have the choice about q.

will perform various actions.

perform a certain action (1,2)

0 We have achieved what we



The fatalist argument